



Scrutiny Committee

16:30 to 18:35

Thursday, 15 January 2026

Present: Councillors Wright (Chair), Galvin (Vice-Chair), Champion, Fulton-McAlister, Hoechner, Kendrick, Lawes, Oliver, Sands (S), Sands (M), Stutely

Apologies: Councillor Smith

In attendance: Councillor Jones, Cabinet Member for Housing
Davina Howes, Executive Director of Communities and Housing
Chris Haystead, Housing Options Manager
Andrew Turnbull, Development Strategy Manager
Robert Carmichael, Democratic Services Manager
Charlotte McCalister, Housing Partnerships Officer
Amy Nagle, Graduate Management Trainee (Communities and Housing)

43. Declarations of Interest

- 43.1 Councillor Stutely declared an other registerable interest as a former Non-Executive Director of Lion Homes, which was relevant to Item 46, Housing Development at Mile Cross Depot Site.

44. Minutes

- 44.1 **RESOLVED** that the public and exempt minutes of the meeting held on 18 December 2025 were confirmed and signed as a true record.
- 44.2 The Chair invited Councillor Galvin, the Committee's representative on the Norfolk Health Overview Select Committee (NHOSC), to provide a brief update on the most recent meeting of the Committee, which took place on 15 January 2026. Councillor Galvin updated Members on the following items:



- Eastern Pathology Alliance (EPA) Weekend Pathology Testing – East Norfolk Medical Practice addressed the Committee about the decision to stop weekend pathology testing. The ICB had explained that its Equalities Impact Assessment had not identified the problems around stopping the service. A report would go to the Committee again at a later date. The Committee had agreed to write to Councillor Graham Plant, Cabinet Member for Highways, Infrastructure and Transport at Norfolk County Council, to ask him to provide a report on bus transport to hospitals.
- Palliative and End of Life Care – The ICB had completed a large review, as had Marie Curie. Reports identified that provision was inconsistent and inequitable across Norfolk. A new service specification was being developed for end-of-life care.
- Norfolk Medicines Support Service – The ICB were due to stop the service as the funding for the service had ended. The Committee had asked Norfolk County Council to explain the decision to end the funding and wanted more information on the impact of stopping the service.
- Forward Work Programme – Several items which impacted Norwich would be discussed in future meetings. This included a strategic review of outreach services, including the Wellness on Wheels bus, which would be pre-scrutinised. The Committee were also informed that the contracts let by the ICB were called in to the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care. There were concerns about who the contracts had been awarded to, which were raised at the meeting.

44.3 Councillor Galvin encouraged Members of the Committee to reach out to her if they wanted to know more about NHOSC.

45. Revisions to the Home Options Policy

45.1 The Cabinet Member for Housing thanked the Scrutiny Committee for the opportunity to present the proposed revisions to the Home Options policy.

45.2 The Housing Options Manager explained that the Council had undertaken consultation and changes to the policy were driven by new legislation and statutory guidance that the Council needed to follow. He highlighted the proposed changes to the policy, which included:

- All applications would involve a discussion of an applicant's housing need with an advisor.
- Applicants must have been continuously resident in Norwich for at least the last two years, in accordance with statutory guidance and to ensure



that the Council's housing policies benefited local people, with some exceptions.

- The number of refusals allowed before an application was cancelled for 12 months would be reduced from five to three to reflect the high demand for social housing.
- Clarification of priority banding for rough sleepers. Where it was confirmed that an applicant was sleeping rough, met the qualification criteria and had no other accommodation available to them, the silver band would be awarded by the Council's rough sleeper team.
- UK armed forces veterans would be prioritised within bands, in accordance with the Armed Forces Covenant.

- 45.3 The Housing Options Manager explained that the proposed changes had been subject to consultation. 72 responses had been received and were detailed in the report. The Chair thanked the Housing Options Manager for the introduction and noted that 72 responses was an improvement on previous years.
- 45.4 A Member asked for more information about the special circumstances in which an applicant would not need to have been a continuous resident in Norwich for at least the previous two years. In response, the Housing Options Manager clarified there were several special circumstances, such as those fleeing domestic violence, where applicants did not need to evidence continuous residence.
- 45.5 In response to a Member's question, the Housing Options Manager explained that in terms of Council accommodation, the only properties that were not able to accept large pets were tower blocks.
- 45.6 Discussion ensued on households. The Housing Options Manager clarified that the Council would not consider relatives who did not form part of the applicant's immediate family where there was no formal care arrangement as part of the applicant's household. This included parents or step-parents, grandparents, siblings or step-siblings, aunts, uncles, grandchildren, nieces, nephews or cousins. The Housing Options Manager explained that anyone outside of the immediate family was excluded as demand was high and prioritisation was necessary. The Cabinet Member for Housing added that given the large demand, the Council sought to free up larger properties and help people to downsize where appropriate. She noted that the need for larger properties was significant, and the Council needed to be realistic about the availability of larger houses and meet the needs of the most vulnerable.
- 45.7 In response to a Member's question, the Housing Options Manager explained that the Council had an arrangement with Dog's Trust for pet fostering.
- 45.8 Discussion ensued on the housing need bands as detailed in the report. A Member was concerned housing arrangements did not facilitate shared custody of children and that children would be penalised for their parents'



decision making. The Housing Options Manager explained that there was not enough housing available to enable an applicant to have a spare bedroom that was vacant, for example, when their child was staying with their other parent. He emphasised that there were families who needed extra rooms permanently and the system sought to prioritise greatest need. Housing benefit issues also had to be considered.

- 45.9 A Member queried how applicants with changing care arrangements, such as fostering children, were considered. The Housing Options Manager explained that the policy stated if someone was fostering or in a foster arrangement, their household would be amended once it was evidenced to officers. He assured Members that the Housing team would support them to find a suitable arrangement.
- 45.10 A Member asked officers to clarify which revisions to the policy were driven by legislation. The Housing Options Manager explained that the addition of the realistic conversation and the reduction in number of refusals were Council additions, and the remaining changes were due to guidance and legislation.
- 45.11 In response to a Member's question, the Housing Options Manager informed Members that the Council had undertaken a publicity drive as part of the Norfolk Armed Forces Covenant Board, to better publicise services for veterans.
- 45.12 A Member sought assurance that the honest and realistic conversations that the Housing team had with applicants were guided by trauma-informed care practices. She noted that she had worked with residents who hadn't been able to complete the process for personal reasons and had been daunted by the prospect of starting the process again. The Housing Options Manager explained that the Council sought to humanise the process by talking to applicants at the beginning and providing them with advice. He added that the Council was part of a trauma-informed practice working group and took a person-centred approach to working with different clients.
- 45.13 Discussion ensued on the Assessment Panel, which was referenced throughout the report. A Member questioned who was on the Panel and requested more information on their decision-making process. The Committee agreed that they would like to see that information outlined within the policy. Officers agreed to provide that information within the policy.
- 45.14 Discussion continued on the implications of the policy on joint-custody households. The Executive Director of Communities and Housing explained that the Council's approach was standard. The Cabinet Member for Housing added that the policy took a realistic approach. Members asked officers to complete some analysis on co-parenting in Council-owned properties. The Executive Director of Communities and Housing agreed that research was likely already available from the housing and voluntary sector which officers would draw on and present back to the Scrutiny Committee at a later date.



45.15 A Member proposed that they would like to ask Cabinet to remove paragraph 3.8.7.3 from the policy. The Executive Director of Communities and Housing explained that the point was about the housing band priority, and it did not prevent families from bidding for a change in property to suit their new circumstances. Several Members stated that the line in the policy was poorly worded and by a majority vote, agreed to ask Cabinet to consider removing the paragraph from the policy.

45.16 **RESOLVED**, by a majority vote, to:

1. Note the proposed policy changes and make any recommendations to Cabinet before its approval and adoption of a new Home Options policy.
2. Ask Cabinet to consider removing paragraph 3.8.7.3 from the proposed policy.

45.17 **RESOLVED** to note the following actions:

1. To include more information about the Assessment Panel in the policy, including the make up of the panel, its governance and decision-making processes and circulate this information to the Scrutiny Committee.
2. Request that officers explore research from national organisations and others regarding the impact co-parenting in Council-owned properties, needs of families and impact and provide a brief update at a future Scrutiny Committee meeting.

46. Housing Development at Mile Cross Depot Site

46.1 The Cabinet Member for Housing introduced the report. She explained that the development at Mile Cross Depot Site had been an interesting and complex process, and much time had been spent on making the site fit for purpose. She informed Members that the Council was continuously seeking opportunities to add to its housing stock.

46.2 The Development Strategy Manager explained that the report outlined the history of the site over the previous 5-7 years. The site had significant ground issues, notably demolished former dwellings and rubble deposited on the site, contamination across the site, a main sewage pipe to the northern boundary and peat to the southern boundary. He reminded Members that the Covid-19 pandemic and introduction of Nutrient Neutrality had also affected the development of the site.

46.3 The Development Strategy Manager explained that since the ground civilisation works were completed at the end of 2023/early 2024, there had been significant progression, with the planning application submitted in February 2024 and approved in November 2024. A decision was taken to do an early stage enabling package of works to de-risk future phases of the



development. The contractor was working on Stage 1 and a pre-construction services agreement. A detailed cost plan would be developed to give cost certainty in the summer of 2026.

- 46.4 The Chair thanked officers for the update and opened the discussion to questions.
- 46.5 In response to a Member's question, the Development Strategy Manager clarified that there would be 67 new affordable homes developed on the site. He also explained that a new bell mouth entrance to the site would be constructed for residents.
- 46.6 Discussion ensued on Local Government Reorganisation (LGR). A Member sought assurance that the development would not be delayed or disrupted due to LGR. The Executive Director of Communities and Housing explained that the Government had made it clear that spending on the Housing Revenue Account (HRA) needed to continue given its importance and the needs of running a housing service. A Member asked whether precautions were in place to prevent a loss of institutional knowledge should there be a high turnover of Council officers due to LGR. The Executive Director of Communities and Housing stated that there needed to be clear governance and business continuity throughout the transition period. She added that information was shared across centralised folders that officers had access to for business continuity. From a resource perspective, the Development Strategy Manager added that his team had secured a new Senior Development Officer in October 2025 and additional interim resource for Mile Cross, demonstrating that the Council retained the ability to recruit.
- 46.7 A Member noted that the Mile Cross site was nearby Sweet Briar marshes, which had become a significant urban wildlife reserve, the Marriott's Way cycle route and the River Wensum and asked how the site would be integrated in the landscape. The Development Strategy Manager responded that a positive of the development was the way it opened up to the Marriott's Way. He explained that there would be connections through to the Marriott's Way and increased lines of visibility across Mile Cross Road to Marriott's Way.
- 46.8 In response to a Member's question, the Development Strategy Manager explained that there would be no gas in any new developments going forward. The Cabinet Member for Housing added that there had been discussions about communal battery storage which she would revisit.
- 46.9 A Member thanked officers for their work on the brownfield site, noting the difficulty that it presented. He sought assurance that there would not be delays on other brownfield sites under development. The Development Strategy Manager explained that whilst he could not predict what would be found under the ground, mitigation measures were in place. He explained that learning from the Mile Cross development had been applied to the Argyle Street scheme and overall, officers recognised that it was appropriate to



spend more time up front de-risking the site, to increase likely contractors who would price competitively.

- 46.10 The Development Strategy Manager detailed learning that had emerged as part of the development of Mile Cross. He explained that he recognised the need to take people on a journey, help them understand the indicative programme of activities and potentially break the development down into phases. There had also been discussions on how to communicate developments with residents and the wider community, including sharing more visual information and regular updates. The Chair agreed that that approach would embed more public confidence and understanding. The Cabinet Member for Housing added that the Housing Hub and the housing updates which she circulated to all Councillors formed part of that effort.
- 46.11 In response to a Member's question, the Cabinet Member for Housing clarified that the Mile Cross development site was always planned to be a HRA site. She explained that the Council wanted to build as much social housing as possible across the City, however, needed to consider multiple sites, competing priorities and capital costs. The focus for Mile Cross was to deliver 67 affordable homes and then consider next steps. The Cabinet Member for Housing explained that competing demands needed to be balanced. The Development Strategy Manager added that the Social and Affordable Homes Programme (SAHP) had been released by Homes England and the Council were exploring the opportunities that that change would bring.
- 46.12 A Member noted that of the 1,008 new houses completed in the City since 2020, 291 were affordable homes. 262 of those 291 were enabled or delivered by the Council, meaning that only 29 affordable units were delivered by private developers. The Development Strategy Manager explained that the Council had provided grants of right to buy receipts through the Section 106 system and was responsible for the majority of affordable housing either through direct delivery on site or by working with partners. A Member commented that that was a concern, but noted that LGR might give the Council more potential outside of the current City boundaries.
- 46.13 The Committee agreed to recommend that subsequent phases were presented to Scrutiny for pre-Scrutiny before going to Cabinet.
- 46.14 A Member was pleased to note that air-source heat pumps and solar panels were to be included in the development and the Committee agreed to ask Cabinet to consider adding battery storage and electric car charging as standard across the site.
- 46.15 Discussion ensued on community engagement. A Member noted that community engagement needed to be embedded within the development and proposed that communities be given opportunities to provide input in the Marriott's Way amelioration work and into the hoardings around the site. The Development Strategy Manager advised that the Marriott's Way was owned by Norfolk County Council, meaning there would need to be liaison with the Council.



46.16 Members thanked officers for their work on the development and were pleased to see that the Council continued to develop houses in challenging circumstances.

46.17 **RESOLVED** to:

1. Note the report.
2. Request that Scrutiny Committee have the opportunity to pre-scrutinise subsequent phases of the Mile Cross development site prior to Cabinet decisions.
3. Commend that there is solar on the site and air source heat pumps.
4. Ask that Cabinet consider adding battery storage and electric car charging as standard across the site.
5. Ask officers to liaise with Norfolk County Council and local community groups to identify wider opportunities for amelioration of the Marriott's Way as part of the development.
6. Ask that communities have the opportunity to provide input and engage with the hoardings.

47. Nutrient Neutrality Review Scope

47.1 The Chair introduced the item. He explained that in May 2025, the Audit Committee resolved to 'request that Scrutiny Committee considers reviewing the current position around Nutrient Neutrality and the mitigations'. The Scrutiny Committee agreed to put the item on their Work Programme and agree to key points that they wanted officers to address in the report. These were:

- Context about Nutrient Neutrality, its introduction and the Council's response.
- Lessons learned regarding the credit scheme.
- The effectiveness of Nutrient Neutrality regulations.
- The effectiveness of mitigation strategies.
- The Council's work with other authorities.
- The impact of nutrients on the River Wensum.
- Assurance that further legislation is considered in a timely manner.
- Value for money of nutrient credit schemes.

47.2 **RESOLVED** to request Democratic Services to share the Committee's key points with officers so that they may draft a report for Scrutiny Committee.

48. Work Programme



- 48.1 A Member requested to add an interim report from the task and finish group, 'Enhancing Deliberative Democracy and Citizen Participation in Decision-Making' to the March meeting of the Scrutiny Committee.
- 48.2 The Chair reminded Members of the Scrutiny Committee to attend Budget Scrutiny training on 29 January 2026.
- 48.3 **RESOLVED** to:
- 1) Add an interim report from the task and finish group, 'Enhancing Deliberative Democracy and Citizen Participation in Decision-Making' to the March meeting of the Scrutiny Committee.
 - 2) Agree the Work Programme.

CHAIR